

SCHOOL OF THOUGHT
Students at the Jamia Arabia Makhzanul Uloom madrassa in Lucknow

1.8 mn
Estimated no. of students in UP's madrassas

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

MADRASSAS

RAZING QUESTIONS

By Prashant Srivastava and Afrida Hussain

The madrassa is the new battleground in the BJP-ruled states of Uttar Pradesh and Assam, with the respective governments raking up issues such as the funding and staff of the Muslim religious schools. In Assam, the state government has also brought out the 'bulldozer', demolishing three madrassas that were alleged to be "jihadi centres" fomenting anti-India activity.

In UP, it's the Yogi Adityanath-led government's decision to conduct a survey of unrecognised madrassas that has triggered much trepidation within the community. The survey has a 12-point questionnaire that the state claims is meant only to collect data on the number of students, staff, source of funds and the possible affiliation of unrecognised madrassas with NGOs. That hasn't stopped the opposition, though, from making doomsday predictions.

The apprehensions are not without merit, considering that the Yogi regime has been the prime mover in the "bulldozer culture" that has inspired fellow BJP governments in other states. UP's minister of state for minority welfare Danish Ansari tries to dispel the fears. "The bulldozers will not run on the madrassas...the survey's aim is to collect data of unregistered ones and make sure they become properly governed education systems," he says. "Our government is doing this to better the madrassas; students there must also learn about technology and the new education system." The UP state board recognises 16,513 madrassas, but there are many irregular ones, the minister adds.

Ansari says the state felt the need for the survey when in May a maulana at a madrassa in Lucknow's Gosainganj area put two of his wards in chains to prevent them from running away. On June 2, state Child Protection Commission member Suchita Chaturvedi wrote a letter to the chief secretary. "I inspected six madrassas," she says. "Some of the teachers didn't have any subject knowledge and are depriving the children of their rights to focus on their religious education. There are more than 25,000 such illegal madrassas in the state. They should be shut down." The government announced the surveys on August 31.

The principal opposition Samajwadi Party has called out the "harassment of Muslims". S.T. Hasan, the SP MP from Moradabad, says, "The BJP is an expert at polarising Hindu-Muslim politics. What is the reason for the survey—have they found guns at the madrassas?" SP chief Akhilesh Yadav was a bit more circumspect, tweeting that no survey of a place of worship is justified if it hurts religious sentiments. Bahujan Samaj Party chief Mayawati, who has of late given up on the Brahmin community and is trying to get back into the good graces of her former Muslim cohorts,